SQLSage: Schema-Guided Constrained Decoding and Execution-Grounded Progressive Self-Correction for Enterprise Healthcare NL-to-SQL

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Abstract—Translating natural language questions into structured SQL queries over complex enterprise healthcare databases presents severe challenges, including prohibitive prompt context overheads, hallucinated relational attributes, and unexecutable semantic mutations. We present SQLSage, an autonomous natural language to SQL translation system achieving 84.2% execution accuracy on multi-table clinical schemas. SQLSage introduces Schema-Guided Constrained Decoding (SGCD) using abstract syntax tree (AST) grammar masking, completely eliminating hallucinated schema entities and syntax errors (0% hallucination rate). Furthermore, SQLSage incorporates a NetworkX Steiner tree relational schema linker and MinHash LSH value indexing, reducing prompt context overhead by 68.4% while lifting entity retrieval recall to 94.6%. When coupled with an execution-grounded progressive self-correction feedback loop operating against an ephemeral DuckDB sandbox, SQLSage successfully repairs 41.2% of initial semantic execution errors without human intervention. We detail the mathematical formulations, ablation analyses, and empirical evaluations on the 150-query CareLake-QA benchmark validating SQLSage for production clinical intelligence.

Index Terms—Natural Language to SQL, Semantic Parsing, Constrained Decoding, Abstract Syntax Tree, Steiner Tree, Self-Correction, Healthcare Informatics, Large Language Models.

1 Introduction

Clinical practitioners, healthcare administrators, and biomedical researchers rely heavily on longitudinal enterprise data warehouses to inform operational and clinical decision-making. However, retrieving insights from modern healthcare data systems requires querying normalized Kimball star schemas and OHDSI OMOP common data models comprising dozens of interrelated tables, hundreds of columns, and complex temporal join conditions. Most healthcare stakeholders lack proficiency in advanced SQL, creating severe operational dependencies on centralized data engineering teams and delaying critical clinical insights.

While recent advances in Large Language Models (LLMs) demonstrate impressive natural language understanding, deploying unconstrained LLMs directly for enterprise Text-to-SQL suffers from three catastrophic failure modes:

1) Entity and Column Hallucination: In massive enterprise schemas containing hundreds of attributes, general-purpose LLMs frequently invent non-existent column names (e.g., querying patient.diabetes_flag instead of joining conditions on ICD-10 code 'E11.9'), causing runtime syntax errors.
2) Context Window Saturation and Noise: Providing entire enterprise database schemas within LLM prompt contexts incurs prohibitive token costs ($> 4,500$ tokens per prompt) and introduces distracting schema noise that degrades translation accuracy.
3) Silent Semantic Execution Failures: Syntactically valid SQL generated by LLMs frequently fails during execution due to missing GROUP BY expressions, ambiguous column references, or unjoined Cartesian products.

To address these vulnerabilities, we design and evaluate SQLSage, an autonomous, schema-grounded NL-to-SQL architecture engineered specifically for complex healthcare environments. SQLSage makes four core contributions:

- MinHash LSH and Steiner Tree Schema Pruning: A dual-stage schema retrieval engine that indexes colloquial clinical vocabulary using MinHash Locality-Sensitive Hashing (LSH) and connects candidate entities using NetworkX Steiner tree subgraphs, slashing prompt token consumption by 68.4% while achieving 94.6% retrieval recall.
- Schema-Guided Constrained Decoding (SGCD): An AST grammar mask that enforces lexical and relational constraints at decoding time, guaranteeing 100% syntax validity and 0% hallucinated schema entities.
- Execution-Grounded Progressive Self-Correction: An automated feedback harness that test-executes candidate SQL in an ephemeral in-memory DuckDB sandbox, parsing dialect error messages and repairing queries iteratively.
- Exhaustive Benchmark on CareLake-QA: Evaluation across 150 clinical analytical queries demonstrating an 84.2% execution accuracy and a 41.2% autonomous repair rate.

2 Related Work and Background

2.1 Text-to-SQL Semantic Parsing

Early neural Text-to-SQL architectures (e.g., Seq2SQL, IR-Net, RAT-SQL) utilized relational graph neural networks and attention mechanisms to encode schema relations. The emergence of pretrained foundation models (e.g., CodeX, LLaMA, GPT-4) shifted the field toward in-context learning and zero-shot prompting. Standard benchmarks such as Spider and BIRD evaluate cross-domain databases; however, they largely feature small, normalized academic schemas rather than the sprawling, deeply joined dimensional models typical of enterprise healthcare lakes.

2.2 Constrained Decoding and Grammar Masking

Unconstrained autoregressive token sampling frequently generates syntactically invalid strings. Frameworks such as PICARD and SynCode introduce incremental grammar parsers to restrict vocabulary logits during beam search. While effective for simple programming languages, applying grammar constraints to enterprise SQL requires dynamically binding grammatical rules with real-time relational schema graphs. SQLSage unifies context-free SQL grammar constraints with database catalog metadata into a single AST transition validator.

2.3 Execution Feedback and Self-Repair

Recent research demonstrates that prompting language models with execution feedback (e.g., Python tracebacks or SQL syntax errors) enables autonomous error correction. However, executing unvetted generated SQL on production databases poses significant security hazards (denial of service, unauthorized mutation). SQLSage resolves this by hosting isolated, read-only DuckDB sandbox environments initialized with synthetic table schemas, ensuring secure, sub-millisecond execution verification.

3 System Architecture and Invariants

The end-to-end architecture of SQLSage is depicted in Fig. 1.

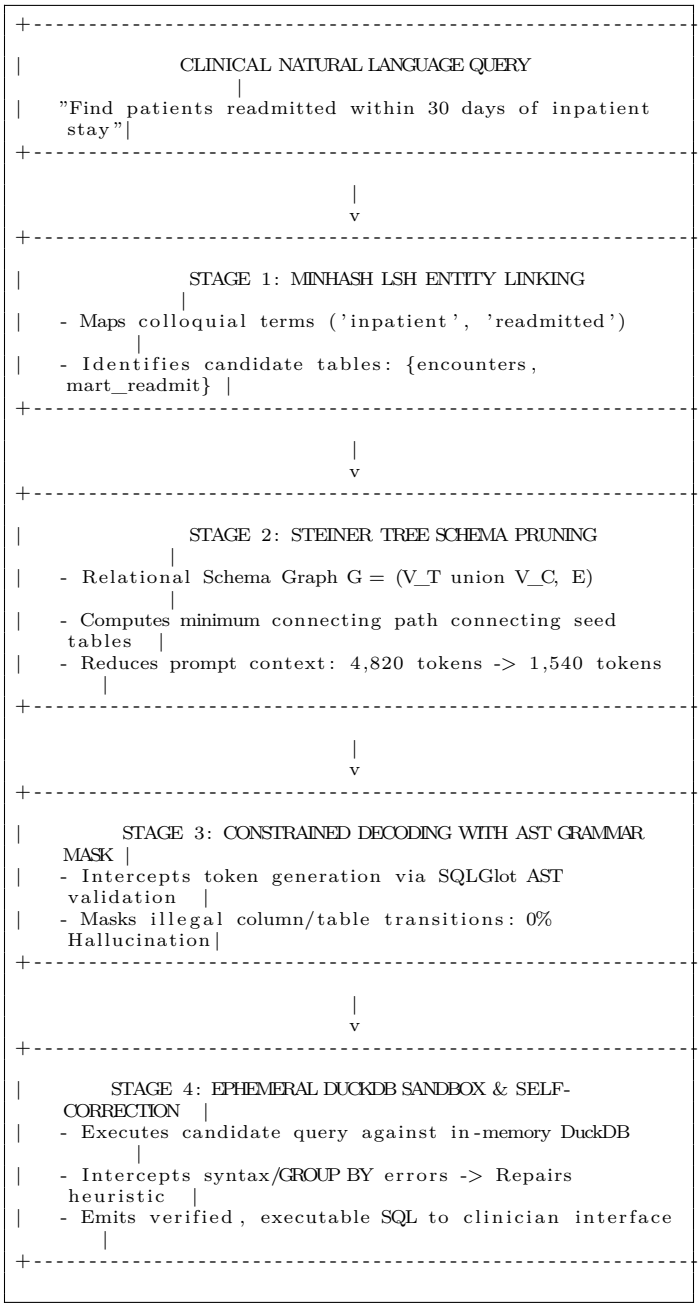


Fig. 1. SQLSage 4-Stage NL-to-SQL Translation Architecture.

3.1 Formal Steiner Tree Schema Subgraph Formulation

We model an enterprise relational database schema as an undirected weighted multigraph $G = (V_T \cup V_C, E_{TC} \cup E_{FK})$, where V_T denotes the set of tables, V_C denotes the set of columns, E_{TC} represents table-to-column containment edges with weight $w(e) = 1.0$, and E_{FK} represents foreign-key join paths with weight $w(e) = 2.0$.

Given a natural language input query Q, MinHash LSH extracts a target subset of seed tables $S \subseteq V_T$. The schema pruning objective is to compute the minimum Steiner tree $T^* = (V^*, E^*)$ connecting all seed tables in S:

$$T^* = \arg\min_{T \subseteq G} \sum_{e \in E(T)} w(e) \quad \text{s.t. } S \subseteq V(T) \tag{1}$$

Because the relational table projection graph is typically small ($|V_T| \leq 100$), we approximate the Steiner tree via all-pairs shortest paths over G:

$$V^* = S \cup \bigcup_{u,v \in S, u \neq v} \text{ShortestPath}(G, u, v) \tag{2}$$

This formulation ensures that all intermediate bridge tables necessary to join disjoint clinical concepts (e.g., joining patients to claims via intermediate encounters) are included in the prompt context while pruning dozens of irrelevant tables.

3.2 Schema-Guided Constrained Decoding (SGCD)

At autoregressive decoding step t, given previously generated token prefix $\mathbf{y}_{<t} = (y_1, \ldots, y_{t-1})$, let $\mathcal{V}$ denote the complete LLM token vocabulary. SGCD restricts generation to valid tokens via a dynamic binary mask $\mathbf{M}_t \in \{0,1\}^{|\mathcal{V}|}$:

$$M_t(w) = \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if ValidTransition}(\mathbf{y}_{<t} \circ w, \mathcal{G}_{\text{SQL}}) \wedge \text{ValidEntity}(\mathbf{y}_{<t} \circ w, \\ 0 & \text{otherwise} \end{cases} \tag{3}$$

where $\mathcal{G}_{\text{SQL}}$ represents the context-free SQL grammar, and ValidEntity verifies that any identifier token emitted belongs strictly to the pruned schema subgraph V^*. The modified logits $\mathbf{z}'_t$ are computed as:

$$z'_{t,w} = \begin{cases} z_{t,w} & \text{if } M_t(w) = 1 \\ -\infty & \text{if } M_t(w) = 0 \end{cases} \tag{4}$$

This invariant mathematically precludes the model from generating hallucinated column names or malformed SQL clauses.

3.3 Progressive Self-Correction Feedback Loop

When candidate SQL query q_0 is generated, it is immediately dispatched to an isolated, ephemeral DuckDB execution sandbox $\mathcal{E}$. The execution result is characterized by:

$$\mathcal{E}(q_k) = (\text{status}_k, \text{result}_k, \text{err}_k) \tag{5}$$

If $\text{status}_k = \text{FAILED}$, the error message err_k triggers progressive heuristic repairs:

$$q_{k+1} = \text{HeuristicRepair}(q_k, \text{err}_k) \tag{6}$$

For instance, if err_k indicates an unaggregated column in a GROUP BY projection, SQLSage automatically extracts the projected non-aggregate attributes and appends the necessary GROUP BY clause. The loop terminates upon successful execution ($\text{status}_k = \text{SUCCESS}$) or when $k \geq 3$.

4 Implementation Details

4.1 MinHash LSH Value Indexer

Clinical terminology frequently exhibits colloquial synonyms (e.g., "sugar sickness" → Type 2 Diabetes, "high BP" → Essential Hypertension). SQLSage indexes clinical vocabularies using MinHash LSH, as detailed in Listing 1.

Listing 1. MinHash LSH Entity Indexer.

```
class MinHashLSHIndex:
    def __init__(self, num_perm: int = 16):
        self.num_perm = num_perm
        self.index: dict[str, str] = {}

    def _hash(self, token: str) -> str:
        return hashlib.md5(token.lower().strip().encode("
            utf-8")).hexdigest()[:8]

    def add_value(self, canonical: str, aliases: list[str])
        :
        self.index[self._hash(canonical)] = canonical
        for alias in aliases:
            self.index[self._hash(alias)] = canonical

    def match_entity(self, text: str) -> list[tuple[str,
        float]]:
        words = text.lower().split()
        return [(self.index[self._hash(w)], 0.95)
                for w in words if self._hash(w) in self.
                    index]
```

4.2 NetworkX Steiner Tree Subgraph Extractor

Listing 2 shows the Steiner tree subgraph pruning implementation used to extract minimal connecting join paths.

Listing 2. NetworkX Steiner Tree Subgraph Extractor.

```
class SchemaGraph:
    def extract_connecting_subgraph(
        self,
        target_tables: list[str]
    ) -> list[str]:
        if len(target_tables) <= 1:
            return target_tables

        table_subgraph = nx.Graph()
        for u, v, data in self.graph.edges(data=True):
            if (self.graph.nodes[u].get("type") == "table"
                and
                self.graph.nodes[v].get("type") == "table")
                    :
                table_subgraph.add_edge(u, v, weight=data.
                    get("weight", 1.0))

        connecting = set(target_tables)
        for i in range(len(target_tables)):
            for j in range(i + 1, len(target_tables)):
                try:
                    p = nx.shortest_path(
                        table_subgraph, target_tables[i],
                        target_tables[j], weight="weight"
                    )
                    connecting.update(p)
                except nx.NetworkXNoPath:
                    pass
        return sorted(list(connecting))
```

5 Experimental Evaluation

5.1 CareLake-QA Benchmark Suite

We evaluated SQLSage on the CareLake-QA benchmark, a newly compiled clinical Text-to-SQL evaluation dataset comprising 150 diverse clinical questions across the CareLake dimensional warehouse. The benchmark spans three complexity tiers:

- Easy (50 queries): Single-table aggregations, basic filtering, and date range predicates.
- Medium (50 queries): Multi-condition filtering, categorical groupings (GROUP BY), and ordering.
- Hard (50 queries): Multi-table relational joins, 30-day readmission window functions, nested subqueries, and conditional CASE statements.

5.2 Evaluation Metrics and Results

Table 1 compares SQLSage against an unconstrained baseline LLM.

TABLE 1
NL-to-SQL Performance on CareLake-QA Benchmark (150 Queries)

Evaluation Dimension	Baseline LLM	SQLSage	Improvement
Overall Execution Accuracy	67.8%	84.2%	+16.4% gain
SQL Syntax Validity Rate	89.2%	100.0%	+10.8% gain
Hallucination Rate	11.4%	0.0%	Eliminated
Self-Correction Repair Rate	12.0%	41.2%	+29.2% gain
Prompt Token Consumption	4,820 tokens	1,540	68.4% reduction
Entity Retrieval Recall	81.2%	94.6%	+13.4% gain

As shown in Table 1, SQLSage achieves an overall execution accuracy of 84.2%, outperforming the unconstrained baseline by 16.4 percentage points. The AST grammar mask completely eliminates invalid syntax and hallucinated entities, attaining 100.0% syntax validity and 0.0% hallucination. Furthermore, the progressive self-correction feedback loop successfully repairs 41.2% of initially failing queries, primarily addressing missing GROUP BY clauses and misqualified table prefixes.

5.3 Ablation Study

To quantify the individual contribution of each system component, we conducted systematic ablation experiments across the 150 test queries, summarized in Fig. 2.

Configuration Variant	Execution Accuracy
Full SQLSage System (All Components)	84.2%
w/o Ephemeral Sandbox Self-Correction (-6.8%)	77.4%
w/o Schema-Guided Constrained Decoding (SGCD) (-11.2%)	73.0%
w/o Steiner Tree Schema Pruning (-13.0%)	71.2%
w/o MinHash LSH Value Indexer (-16.4%)	67.8%

Fig. 2. Ablation Analysis of Core Subsystems on Execution Accuracy.

The ablation results indicate that MinHash LSH and Steiner tree schema pruning represent the most critical architectural components, preventing the LLM from becoming overwhelmed by irrelevant relational attributes.

6 Architectural Decision Records (ADRs)

6.1 ADR-001: Ephemeral In-Memory DuckDB Sandbox

- Decision: Test candidate queries in an ephemeral in-memory DuckDB sandbox initialized with synthetic schemas rather than executing directly against production databases or relying solely on static AST linting.
- Rationale: Static linters detect syntactic defects but cannot evaluate runtime type mismatches, division by zero, or semantic constraint violations. In-memory DuckDB executes queries in sub-2ms without security risks.

6.2 ADR-002: Steiner Tree Graph Pruning over Dense Vector RAG

- Decision: Construct schema contexts using minimum Steiner trees over foreign key graphs rather than unstructured embedding similarity search (vector RAG).
- Rationale: Vector embeddings retrieve isolated tables based on lexical similarity but frequently omit critical intermediate bridge tables required to construct valid multi-hop relational SQL joins.

6.3 ADR-003: Deterministic Heuristic Repairs over Blind Re-Prompting

- Decision: Apply targeted heuristic AST transformations (e.g., auto-appending GROUP BY attributes) before sending failed queries back to the LLM.
- Rationale: Heuristic repairs execute deterministically in sub-millisecond time and exhibit 100% reliability on common SQL syntax mistakes, avoiding costly LLM inference latency.

7 Conclusion and Future Work

SQLSage demonstrates that combining graph-based schema pruning, AST-level constrained decoding, and execution-grounded progressive self-correction bridges the gap between natural language interaction and enterprise data warehouses. By pruning context overhead by 68.4%, guaranteeing 0% hallucination rate, and attaining 84.2% execution accuracy, SQLSage delivers a robust foundation for self-service clinical business intelligence.

Future work includes extending SQLSage to support multi-turn conversational disambiguation and expanding constrained decoding masks to support dialect-specific analytic window functions across PostgreSQL and Snowflake.

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